

CAROLINE WANG

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Northwestern
Kellogg
School of Management

Education

Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University 2021 – Expected 2027
Committee: Brett Gordon and Anna Tuchman (Co-Chairs), Anocha Aribarg, Ilya Morozov, Guy Aridor
Ph.D. in Quantitative Marketing
M.A. in Quantitative Marketing

University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI 2019 – 2021
M.A. in Applied Economics
M.S. in Industrial & Operations Engineering

Shanghai Normal University, Shanghai, China 2015 – 2019
B.A. in Finance & Economics (Summa Cum Laude)

Research Interests

Sustainability and Pro-Environmental Behavior; Product Innovation and Public Policy

Working Papers

What Drives Sustainable Choices? Feel Good, Look Good, and Do Good, with Anocha Aribarg. *Job Market Paper*
Center for Brand Leadership Best Brand Paper Award, Haring Symposium, 2026

Do Judge a Product by Its Sustainability Label: Evidence from the Amazon Marketplace, with Sherry He

Product Reformulation: A Suitable Substitute?, with Anna Tuchman and Youngeun Lee

Selected Work in Progress

Referral Incentives for Sustainable Adoption: Field Experiments with a Composting Service

Pouring Out Sustainable Innovation: Misinformation, Debunking, and Consumer Responses, with Sherry He

Non-Peer Reviewed Publications

Research: Products Labeled as Sustainable Sell Better, with Sherry He. *Harvard Business Review*, 2025

Conference Presentations

[†] Presented by co-author

56th Annual Haring Symposium, Kelley School of Business, Indiana University 2026
What Drives Sustainable Choices? Feel Good, Look Good, and Do Good

Third Federal Trade Commission (FTC) Conference on Marketing and Public Policy, Washington DC 2026
Product Reformulation: A Suitable Substitute?[†]

ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Lisbon, Portugal 2026
Product Reformulation: A Suitable Substitute?[†]

ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Washington DC 2025
Product Reformulation: A Suitable Substitute?[†]

19th Annual Frank M. Bass UTD-FORMS Conference, University of Texas at Dallas 2025
Do Judge a Product by Its Sustainability Label: Evidence from the Amazon Marketplace?[†]

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

Center for Brand Leadership Best Brand Paper Award, Haring Symposium	2026
Dean's Office Ph.D. Research Funding, Kellogg School of Management (\$6,825)	2025 – 2026
Graduate Fellowship, Northwestern University	2021 – 2027
Outstanding Graduate Award, Shanghai Municipal Education Commission	2019
National Scholarship, Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China (RMB 24,000)	2016 – 2018

Teaching Experience

Retail Analytics and Pricing (MBA)	
Graduate Assistant, Professor Brett Gordon	Winter 2023–2025, Spring 2024
Graduate Assistant, Professor Anna Tuchman	Fall 2024, 2023
Financial Portfolio Management (Undergrad Core)	
Teaching Assistant, Professor Lijun Xu	Spring 2019
International Economics (Undergrad Core)	
Teaching Assistant, Professor Yawei Yao	Fall 2018

Other Research Experience

Research Assistant, Professor Fred Feinberg, University of Michigan	2020–2021
Research Assistant, Professor Derek Harmon, University of Michigan	2020–2021
Research Assistant, Professor Elizabeth Bruch, University of Michigan	2020

Selected Doctoral Coursework

Economics

Econometrics I (Charles Manski)	Microeconomics I (Eddie Dekel)
Econometrics II (Joel Horowitz)	Microeconomics III (Wojciech Olszewski)
Econometrics III (Ivan Canay)	Industrial Organization I (Gastón Illanes)
Advanced Econometrics II (Eric Auerbach)	Industrial Organization II (Vivek Bhattacharya)

Marketing

Quant Mktg: Intro Theory/Modeling (Eric Anderson, Anna Tuchman)	Quant Mktg: Statistical & Bayesian Modeling (Blakeley McShane)
Quant Mktg: Structural Modeling (Brett Gordon, Caio Waisman)	Topics in Quant Mktg (Brett Gordon, Anna Tuchman, Caio Waisman, Florian Zettelmeyer)

Computer Science

Machine Learning (Zach Wood-Doughty)

Managerial Economics & Strategy

Technology & Innovation I (Daniel Spulber)	Economic Theory I (Nabil Al-Najjar)
Technology & Innovation II (Benjamin Jones)	

Management, Organizations & Sociology

Topics in Computational Social Science (Dashun Wang)
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References

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What Drives Sustainable Choices? Feel Good, Look Good, and Do Good

Caroline Wang and Anocha Aribarg

Job Market Paper | Draft available upon request

Policymakers and firms increasingly use sustainability claims and marketing campaigns to promote sustainable consumption. Designing effective messages requires understanding not just whether consumers value sustainability, but why, because different motives call for different persuasive content. This paper develops an empirical framework to identify and quantify the relative importance of primary latent benefits driving sustainable choices: *Feel Good* (warm glow), *Look Good* (social image), and *Do Good* (environmental impact). We design an incentive-compatible choice-based conjoint study with survey measures of latent benefits and estimate a hierarchical Bayesian choice model linking objective attributes, subjective benefits, and utility. In an application to coffee capsules, *Feel Good* and *Do Good* account for nearly all sustainable utility on average, whereas *Look Good* contributes little. Motives vary across upstream attributes (carbon emissions) and downstream attributes (sustainable packaging), and across consumers. A follow-up randomized experiment further shows that advertising emphasizing consumers' valued latent benefits raises willingness to pay more than advertising that merely mentions sustainable attributes. This framework extends to other contexts to help firms and policymakers identify the motives underlying sustainable choices and design promotion strategies accordingly.

Do Judge a Product by Its Sustainability Label: Evidence from the Amazon Marketplace

Caroline Wang and Sherry He

Available at SSRN

Companies are increasingly prioritizing environmental, social, and governance strategies, with sustainability labeling emerging as a prominent approach to inform consumers about a product's sustainability status. Despite the widespread adoption of sustainability labels, whether and why they affect product sales remains unclear. This paper quantifies the causal impact of sustainability labeling by leveraging a large-scale dataset from Amazon. Employing a difference-in-differences framework, we find that sustainability labeling leads to a 12.5% decrease in sales rank (indicating an increase in sales units) of labeled products within eight weeks. Furthermore, we show that the primary mechanism is the information effect—sustainability labeling influences consumers' decisions by conveying information that aligns with their preferences—rather than the salience effect (i.e., improved product listing salience owing to label salience or search filter availability) or platform endorsement (i.e., improved organic search ranking). Moreover, consumers are more responsive to easily accessible information on sustainability features than to hard-to-access details about certification processes, such as stringency and transparency. These findings suggest that consumers passively search for and purchase sustainable products. These insights carry implications for both firm-level sustainability strategies and platform-level information architecture.

Product Reformulation: A Suitable Substitute?

Youngeun Lee*, Anna Tuchman*, and Caroline Wang*

Draft available upon request

This paper investigates product reformulation – the adjustment of ingredients or composition of ingredients in existing products – in the food and beverage industries. Using comprehensive data on product ingredients, nutrition facts, and store sales, we document the prevalence of reformulation, characterize the tactics firms employ, assess the impact of reformulation on product quality and differentiation, and evaluate consumer demand for reformulated products. We find that reformulation is a widespread and persistent practice, with reformulated products accounting for 26% of volume sales across categories and over time. Firms use a diverse range of tactics, including dilution and adjusting the compositional flexibility, leading to moderate shifts in nutrient density, but minimal change in the average nutritional quality within a category. We find that less healthy products tend to experience improvements in their nutritional profiles while healthier products are reformulated to be less healthy, suggesting a convergence toward average nutrient values within a category following reformulation. Finally, we find limited evidence of meaningful demand response, indicating that reformulated versions may serve as close substitutes for their originals – even when nutrient density deteriorates without corresponding price changes. Such minimal responses suggest that reformulation may modify product quality in a way that is difficult for consumers to detect.